what that means—have either stopped or reversed course." If anyone questioned the propriety of the CIA chief interrupting of the secretary of state's presentation, their concerns vanished as soon as he broke the news. Rusk asked what "Cuban waters" meant. McNamara suggested that the reference was to ships leaving Cuba, but Kennedy asked for clarification: "Why do not we find out whether they are talking about the ships leaving Cuba or the ones coming in?" Rusk provoked laughter when he added: "Makes some difference."[17]

McCone immediately left the room to investigate the report. Kennedy and his advisers continued discussing how the submarines accompanying the *Kimovsk* and the *Gagarin* could be made to surface. McNamara suggested practice depth charges. "Warning depth charges will be used if sonar signal does not get through," were McNamara's words as recorded by Robert Kennedy in his notes on the meeting. He continued with the president's reaction: "I assume if we sink [a] Russian ship that they will close down Berlin." John Kennedy was growing steadily more tense. The ghost of nuclear war was rising in his imagination from beneath the waves hundreds of miles away.

"We don't want the first thing we attack as a Soviet submarine," John Kennedy told his aides. "I would rather have a merchant ship." But McNamara would not back down. He was adamant that the Soviet submarines should be forced to surface before anything was done with the *Kimovsk* or the *Gagarin*. "I think it would be extremely dangerous, Mr. President, to try to defer attack on this submarine in the situation we are in," he told Kennedy. "We could easily lose an American ship by that means." The president gave up. "OK. Let's proceed," he was caught saying by the secret microphone in the Cabinet Room. "President Kennedy had initiated the course of events, but he no longer had control over them," wrote Robert Kennedy later. It was a key moment in the deliberations: the president had signed off on the order to intercept Soviet ships.[18]

Across the table, Robert Kennedy saw the signs of his brother's disturbance. "His hand went up to his face and covered his mouth," he wrote later. "He opened and closed his fist. His face seemed drawn, his eyes pained." Their eyes met. "For a few fleeting seconds, it was almost as though no one else was there and he was no longer the President," recalled